

Unexpected Results

Everyone has opinions about AI’s future, whether they’re AI Worriers or AI Optimists. No matter how confident those people are, there’s a single truth about the future: the biggest results are usually what no one predicted.

The best way to see it is a true story about rats.

HANOI, 1902

The city had a big problem. There were too many rats in the new sewers. No worries. They devised a perfect plan. Turn in a rat’s tail, collect a payment. Tails poured in by the thousands. The brilliance of the plan!

Then people saw something very strange: rats running around the city with no tails. What do you think happened? Time to practice those advanced critical thinking skills!

It was another math thing. Rats can live a relatively full “rat life” even without their tails, and keep having more rat babies. The rat hunters, even without AI, came up with a clever plan to keep the rat-tail supply strong. They clipped the tails, but let the rats live. A dead rat pays once. A live rat pays forever.

Some rat entrepreneurs went even further. They started **rat farms**. You probably know where this is going. When Hanoi stopped the program, they had a mountain of rat tails, but more rats than when it started.

What’s the moral of this story? Every part of the government’s plan worked. People hunted rats, delivered their tails, and received payments of one cent per tail. But the boom in the rat population was the opposite of their goal: a true unexpected result.

UNEXPECTED RESULTS

Once you see that shape, you find it everywhere. Four famous plans, and where each one actually landed. Two turned out better than anyone predicted, two turned out worse.

**Text messaging**

THE PLAN
Engineers bolted SMS onto the phone network in 1992 as a leftover-bandwidth utility: 160 characters, handy for testing.

BETTER THAN THE PREDICTION
It became the main way a generation communicates. No phone company predicted texting.

**GPS**

THE PLAN
A U.S. military system for guiding ships, planes, and missiles.

BETTER THAN THE PREDICTION
Opened to civilians, it put a map in every pocket: turn-by-turn directions, ride-hailing, finding your lost phone. None of that was in the plan.

**Cane toads**

THE PLAN
Australia imported 102 cane toads in 1935 to eat the beetles destroying sugar cane.

WORSE THAN THE PREDICTION
The toads ignored the beetles, ate almost everything else, and spread by the millions. The fix became a bigger plague than the problem.

**Wider highways**

THE PLAN
Texas spent \$2.8 billion widening Houston’s Katy Freeway to 26 lanes, one of the widest in the world, to end rush-hour traffic.

WORSE THAN THE PREDICTION
More lanes invited more drivers. Within a few years, commutes ran up to 51% slower than before the expansion. The same math as the rats.

THE ONE SURE THING

Now point that history at AI. Every AI expert, Optimist and Worrier alike, is making a prediction about the future. Smart and informed predictions, every one. The most important thing AI does in your lifetime, good or bad, may be something nobody in any camp, any lab, or any course has thought of yet.

That’s not a reason to fear the future. It’s the reason to walk into it curious, with your eyes open.

You do not need to predict the future perfectly. You need to recognize uncertainty, watch what people actually do, and build skills that still matter when the forecast changes.

The biggest results are the ones nobody predicted.

That’s the best reason to stay curious.